

BRADFORD STARKE, INC.

COR FIRST MEETING RAPPORT GUIDE

How to Walk Into a Cold Introduction and Walk Out With a Real Relationship

Federal Business Development Toolkit | 2026 Edition
For Internal Use Only — Not for Distribution

BLUF — BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

A Contracting Officer's Representative (COR) is not a procurement contact. They are a human being doing a hard job with limited resources and no time. The consultants who win long-term federal business are not the ones with the best capability statements — they are the ones the COR actually wants to call back. This guide is not about what to sell. It is about how to listen, how to make someone feel genuinely understood, and how to become the person they trust before the next solicitation ever drops.

THE MINDSET — BEFORE YOU SAY ANYTHING

Read this page before the meeting. Not in the parking lot. The night before.

70 / 30 Rule	You talk 30% of the time. They talk 70%. If you're talking more than that, you've shifted from discovery to pitching. Stop. Ask another question.
The Pause	After they answer, wait three full seconds before you respond. It feels uncomfortable. Do it anyway. People fill silence with truth.
Mirror Their Language	If they say 'it's a lot of moving parts,' use that phrase back later. Mirroring language signals alignment without you having to say a word about it.
No Jargon Cold	Do not use FAR, PWS, CPARS, or any acronym until they use it first. On a cold introduction, jargon signals you're selling. Plain language signals you're listening.
One Follow-Up per Answer	Never ask two questions in a row. Ask one. Listen fully. Then ask one follow-up based on what they actually said — not what you planned to ask next.
Read the Room	If they check their watch, wrap up. If they lean forward, go deeper. Physical cues tell you more than any script.

MEETING CONTEXT	
DATE: _____	AGENCY / OFFICE: _____
COR NAME: _____	PROGRAM / CONTRACT: _____
MEETING LOCATION / FORMAT: _____	REFERRED BY: _____

PHASE 1 | THE OPENING — Make It Human Before It's Business

The first 90 seconds set the tone for the entire relationship. People decide if they like you before they decide if they trust you. Lead with curiosity about them — not your company, not your capabilities.

1 WHAT TO SAY
"I really appreciate you taking the time. I know COR responsibilities get layered on top of an already full workload — how long have you been carrying this role?"

Why this works: Acknowledging their burden before they say a word signals that you already respect their position. It invites them to vent just enough to feel heard.

If they open up: If they laugh or sigh — that's the opening. Say: "It sounds like it keeps you busy." Then stop talking.

2 WHAT TO SAY

"Before we get into anything, I'm just curious — how did you end up in this role? Did you volunteer or did someone volunteer you?"

Why this works: This is a genuinely funny, universally relatable question in government. It almost always gets a laugh. Laughter = trust. You've just humanized the conversation in 10 seconds.

If they open up: Listen for their backstory. Remember one detail — their branch, their agency's mission, how long they've been in federal service. Reflect it back later.

3 WHAT TO SAY

"What agency or office are you supporting right now — and what's the mission on your end of this contract?"

Why this works: Asking about their mission — not just their contract — tells them you see them as a professional, not a procurement vehicle.

If they open up: If they describe something meaningful (veterans, health, defense), say: "That's important work." Mean it.

NOTES:

PHASE 2 | FIND THE FRICTION — Let Them Tell the Story

Don't interrogate. Don't pitch. Just create space for them to talk. The best thing you can do in this phase is ask one question, then go quiet. Silence is not awkward — it's productive.

4 WHAT TO SAY

"What does a typical week look like for you managing this contract? Walk me through it."

Why this works: Open-ended and non-threatening. 'Walk me through it' signals you want the real story, not the official one. You'll hear where their energy goes — and where it drains.

If they open up: When they pause, say: "And what's the part that takes the most out of you?" Then write down exactly what they say.

5 WHAT TO SAY

"What's the one thing about this program that you wish worked differently — even a small thing?"

Why this works: 'Even a small thing' removes the pressure to have a dramatic complaint. People open up when they don't feel like they're filing a formal grievance.

If they open up: If they give you something small, probe gently: "And is that just an inconvenience, or does it actually slow the mission down?"

6 WHAT TO SAY

"If you could hand one task on this contract to someone else tomorrow and never think about it again — what would it be?"

Why this works: This question gets to the pain point faster than any compliance-focused question ever will. It's specific, it's personal, and it's almost always answered honestly.

If they open up: That task — whatever it is — is your first potential value-add. Don't pitch it yet. File it mentally.

7 WHAT TO SAY

"Does the contractor you're working with now make your job easier or harder? You don't have to be diplomatic — I'm just trying to understand the landscape."

Why this works: 'You don't have to be diplomatic' is the most powerful phrase in a discovery conversation. It gives them permission to be honest without feeling unprofessional.

If they open up: If they hesitate, say: "I get it — you don't have to say anything specific. But I'm always trying to understand what good actually looks like from the COR's seat."

NOTES:

PHASE 3 | BUILD THE BRIDGE — Show You're Different

You are not pitching here. You are demonstrating — through the quality of your questions and your listening — that you operate differently than every other vendor who walked into their office. That difference is the pitch.

8 WHAT TO SAY

"I ask a lot of questions because I believe the best partnerships are built on actually understanding the mission — not just the contract. Does that approach work for you?"

Why this works: This reframes you from vendor to strategic partner in one sentence. Asking if it works for them shows confidence without arrogance.

If they open up: Almost everyone says yes. If they say 'I appreciate that' — you have rapport.

9 WHAT TO SAY

"What would it look like if a contractor made your COR responsibilities genuinely easier — not just checking the boxes?"

Why this works: This is the most important question in the entire guide. Their answer is your value proposition — in their own words. Write it down verbatim.

If they open up: If they describe something you can actually deliver, say: "That's exactly the kind of thing we've focused on building into how we work. I'd love to show you that at some point."

10 WHAT TO SAY

"Is there anything about the way this contract is currently set up — the reporting, the communication cadence, anything — that you'd redesign if you could?"

Why this works: This invites strategic thinking. CORs who engage with this question are telling you they care about outcomes, not just compliance. These are your best future clients.

If they open up: Whatever they describe, say: "That makes complete sense from where you're sitting." Validation before positioning — always.

NOTES:

PHASE 4 | THE CLOSE — Leave a Door, Not a Business Card

The goal of a first conversation is a second conversation. Don't try to close a deal. Close the relationship. One specific, low-pressure commitment beats a stack of brochures every time.

11 WHAT TO SAY

"This has been really helpful — I feel like I actually understand what you're dealing with now. Would it be okay if I followed up in a few weeks, just to keep the conversation going?"

Why this works: 'Just to keep the conversation going' removes all sales pressure. You're not asking for a meeting. You're asking to be a person they stay in touch with.

If they open up: Get a direct email. Not a general inbox. A direct email means they said yes to you specifically.

12 WHAT TO SAY

"I'm going to be putting together some thoughts based on what you shared today. If I came across something that I thought could genuinely help your program, would you be open to a quick conversation about it?"

Why this works: 'Genuinely help your program' — not 'our services' — keeps the focus on them. This is planting a seed, not pitching a product.

If they open up: If they say yes, you have soft permission to bring a targeted capability brief to the next conversation.

13 WHAT TO SAY

"Before I let you go — is there anyone else on your team I should be aware of? Technical leads, budget folks, anyone who shapes how this program runs?"

Why this works: Every name they give you is a relationship and a new intelligence source. This single question can open three more doors.

If they open up: Ask: "Would it be okay to mention your name when I reach out?" If yes — that's a warm referral. That's gold.

NOTES:

PRO-TIP: Within 24 hours, send a three-sentence follow-up. Sentence one: thank them for their time. Sentence two: reference one specific thing they said — by name. Sentence three: confirm the next step you agreed on. That email alone will put you ahead of 90% of your competition.